

Then there's another category of people who turn to exercise because they're finding that things they could do without thinking 10 or 20 years ago are much harder. Suddenly, gardening, housework, or doing a favorite sport aren't as easy as they once were. For these people, exercise is a route to becoming strong and supple enough to keep on doing the things they've always done.

The health benefits

We all know more or less what we could be doing to benefit our bodies. Regular exercise promotes better cardiovascular and respiratory function. Studies have shown, beyond doubt, that it reduces the risks of coronary heart disease, lowers blood pressure, and also increases levels of "good" cholesterol. It can stabilize blood sugar levels and so can help prevent or control Type II diabetes. It also improves bone density, which protects against osteoporosis. What is more, exercise can help delay some of the physiological effects of aging and creates beneficial changes in the metabolism of the body, for instance speeding up the rate at which it burns calories (see p.98).

Additionally, exercise helps to combat sleep disorders such as insomnia, and it brings psychological benefits, too, for instance releasing stress and improving self-confidence. These days exercise is frequently prescribed for patients with depression, and can be as effective as some anti-depressant medications. On top of that, regular exercise is linked to better sexual function and an increased sex drive.

Working out regularly promotes stronger bones, flexible muscles, better posture and breathing function, and a generally more efficient body—all of which means you will look better. And we all know that it's easier to relate to results we can see, such as improved muscle tone or weight loss, than to "invisible" improvements in cholesterol, blood pressure, and bone density levels. However, remember you will be reaping benefits in those areas, too, as a bonus, whether you are interested in them or not. So what in the world are you waiting for? Start exercising!

>> top tips to stay motivated

- **Find a form of exercise** you enjoy so you'll be sure to look forward to it. There are so many types to choose from, there's bound to be one for you.
- **Results are key**, so take advice (and read this book) to find out what exercise gives fast, lasting results. Once you see your body change for the better, it will reduce your chances of giving up.
- **Training for a particular event** is a great way to stay on track. Fun runs and mini triathlons are ideal for helping you to stay focused as you work toward the big day.
- **Keep your body on its toes**. Like you, your body loves variety, so make small changes in your workout from time to time. That keeps *you* interested and wakes your body up and helps it to burn more calories.
- **Stopped seeing results?** Change your program, try a different class, or work with a different piece of equipment. Just as small changes in your workout can give your body a jump-start, so a complete change is as good as a full engine tune-up.
- **Use a personal trainer**. Seeing a personal trainer, even if it's just once or twice so they can design a personalized plan for you, can give you a boost and accelerate your progress once you are up and running.
- **Work with a friend**. If you train with an exercise buddy, you'll find it that much harder to skip a session than if you're home alone.
- **If finding even 15 minutes** a day is beyond you right now, work some extra activity into your life. Try gardening, walking part of the way to work, or cycling.